which sub-imperial courts imagined their place in this new world order. In these accounts, we can see how the writers used their skill and imagination to describe their heroic patrons who had been fully absorbed into the Mughal Empire. On the one hand, they had to make sure that a suitable deference was observed where the Mughal Padshah was concerned. On the other, the writers had to present their Rajput patron as a heroic and virile figure for two other groups of intended listeners—other elite Rajput clans and the patron's dependants. Therefore these texts were rarely 'histories' in the conventional sense, or in the sense that the Mughal court was producing them, but they are nonetheless a glimpse into the ways in which the regional courts and rulers built a new scaffolding for their unfolding ambitions.

Sreenivasan has shown that the *Mancarit* is also possibly the earliest account of an exalted Kachhwaha genealogy. Using Puranic symbols, the Kachhwahas are described as descending from Brahma himself, via Raghu. Puranic genealogies had been produced for Rajasthani chiefs from the late fifteenth century onwards, naming the patrons as descended either from the sun or the moon. In the sixteenth century, the audience for these genealogies now included the Mughal emperors, who were also interested in the notions of ancestry—as a result, the construction of Puranic genealogies became further validated. Indeed, since the Mughal Padshahs were now confirming the succession of Rajput rulers, as Eaton has pointed out, these detailed genealogies supported by Charans and poems 'had the effect not only of sharpening the boundaries between Rajput clans, but also —because there were fierce struggles with other peoples in the region—of shaping the identity of Rajputs as against non-Rajputs'.

Written in 1585, at a time when Akbar's rise was inexorable, the *Mancarit* for all its staunch praise of the equation between its Rajput patron and the Mughal emperor nonetheless, almost inadvertently, hints at a sense of disquiet and even foreboding at the immense changes that had taken place in the Hindustani landscape, and speaks of the age as Kaliyug.

Just as he would carefully weigh the messages in Persian and Sanskrit outside his palace walls at Rohtas for a wider Hindustani audience, in the *Mancarit*, Raja Man Singh would also patronize a Brajbhasha text that would celebrate the splendour of a Rajput raja while parsing the truth wherever it proved altogether unacceptable.